

Jamictionary

Dear reader,

This is a short intro to the "Jamictionary" : a compilation of music scores for some of the most frequently danced tunes in the European Balfolk scene and some of the most danced tunes in local folk dance floors. Some of the content came from noting what is being played in festivals throughout Europe, others from studying the music scene of specific regions. This database is designed to be used in multiple ways :

- As a leadsheet for the live performance in a jam session.
- As a collaborative database for dance music.
- As a music reading and training tool.
- As an enabler of transformation in the instrument hierarchy of jam sessions.

The what and why

The goal of the Jamictionary is twofold :

- To achieve a minimum common repertoire in the Balfolk jam sessions throughout Europe.
- To raise the cultural and performance bar by introducing an organised map of the very extensive European folk and neo-folk dance music.

Up to a point, it follows the blueprint of jazz's reference jam session book, "The Real Book." It then abandons the binding to exist as a shared folder on the internet that you can save on your computer. Each tune has two files: a PDF file and a MuseScore file. MuseScore is a software that allows you to edit the tunes, so you can create multiple versions of one score. There are no standards for the tunes : the melodies and chords I've provided are only suggestions. The software opens the door for the music jam be coordinated by any instrument as it makes real-time transposition of any music a possibility.

Legal considerations

MuseScore is free (and legal!). I learned most of the tunes by ear and then painfully transcribed them into the software. Money is not a factor for me, the Jamictionary is not for sale. I started this database because the rain wouldn't stop in November of 2022, and I was looking for a way to pass the time. Unless I find out otherwise, all of this work is legal.

How it is organised

The database owes its name (the amalgamation of Jam and Dictionary) to the organisation of the content. It is divided into 2 main categories :

- Dance families (mazurka, waltz, bourrée, etc.), organised in alphabetical order. Most tunes belong to this category. They are often further organised into subcategories (i.e., the two-time and the tree-time bourrée).
- Singles. This exceptional category incorporates the tunes that are specific to a single dance (Mardi Gras, Alunelul, Rumelaj, etc.). This separation between dance families and singles already exists in traditional Irish folk music, and they refer to "singles" as "set dances." The singles are not reorganised into subcategories.

The future

- Of the database: The shared folder is a transitory format, it will be transformed into a website. That will allow to a multi-criteria search of the music (by dance type, by region, by difficulty level, by key, etc), solving one of the biggest problem of large databases. It will also make it easier to find and share.
- Of the usage of the database. If everything goes well, the general dance music performance will improve: local Balfolk jam sessions will be much livelier and they will be a meeting place for different generations and musical logics; a lot more dance genres will be played; a broader view of European Balfolk music will happen; It'll be a party. If everything goes poorly, this will be just another half-hidden musical database, and a handful of people will use it for gigs without ever mentioning its existence.

Let's jam!

João Valente,
Porto, July 2025